FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The sixth Indo-Pakistan war ended as suddenly as it began. It came dangerously close to hitting full throttle before an uneasy truce dawned—not a ceasefire, but an "understanding", in India's words. That peace came in a rather curious manner, with both sides claiming victory, as they have done on similar occasions in the past. As the India-Pakistan conflict leapt up entire rungs of the escalatory ladder within a space of 88 hours, the world was watching anxiously. No one wanted the retaliatory cycle to become a spiral difficult to tame: two hot-headed neighbours with nuclear bombs did not bode well for anyone. The US, the main actor in a buzzing backchannel, weighed in with some distress diplomacy. It succeeded in applying emergency brakes, but the manner of execution muddied the tenuous peace right on its arrival.

President Donald Trump, overzealous and self-aggrandising, elicited from New Delhi a sharp reaction that was both a 'thank you' and a 'no, thank you'. In his usual cavalier manner, he claimed he had averted a nuclear conflict. To New Delhi's chagrin, he re-hyphenated India and Pakistan, that too by putting the source of terror and its victim on the same moral footing, mollycoddling both patronisingly. Not only did Trump jump the gun by breaking the news of the ceasefire, Secretary of State Marco Rubio worsened it by announcing Indo-Pak talks at a neutral venue. India was even more furious as Trump sought to insinuate himself into the Kashmir frame, with all his ignorance of history, by offering to solve the "1,000-year dispute". It took Prime Minister Narendra Modi's combative speech on May 12 to set the record straight.

He didn't mince his words, pointing out it was Pakistan that begged for the ceasefire. Operation Sindoor was not over, he said. This was just a pause, and any fresh act of terror would elicit an even stronger retaliation. Geography would not be a constraint, he warned. India would go after them anywhere, and as high up the pecking order of terror as was necessary. Modi also reiterated that trade and talks can't go together with terror. And that blood and water could not flow at the same time, indicating that India's suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty would remain till Pakistan mended its ways. Kashmir, especially, was off the table entirely and if at all it was broached, "it would be only about PoK". Modi also declared that India had successfully called Pakistan's nuclear bluff, and showed it wouldn't succumb to blackmail. With this address, he laid down stringent red lines which Pakistan would cross at its peril.



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With the 2025 strikes, Modi has set a far higher bar of deterrence for Pakistan's military-jihadi nexus. His punitive doctrine is now set in stone. The next time the Pakistan establishment is tempted to plot transgression, they will think not twice but thrice. Yet, it's a precarious peace. Pakistan refuses to relinquish its claims on Kashmir and runs a proxy war against India through the terrorists it fosters on its soil. For India, Kashmir is not on the table for discussion except, as the prime minister said, for uniting the two Kashmirs. It is an impossible impasse, but the self-serving Pakistan army keeps it on the boil to justify its own grip on power. It is somewhat laughable how Pakistan continues to deny the existence of terror training camps in spite of a mountain of evidence. It is surprising that a bankrupt country should be provoking war. India is now in a bit of dilemma. Will it commit itself to such high-octane action for every instance of terrorism? There is a danger, too, that autonomous non-state actors with all kinds of vested interests can provoke a war. India will have to ensure that the threshold of action against Pakistan will be crossed only by showing the world a solidly evidence-based chain of causation.

In our cover story, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa surveys this complex post-war landscape for insights and clues on what happens next. A graphic-rich presentation captures the first hot war of the digital age between two nuclear nations in all its grey granularity. But the urgent questions that smite us are geostrategic in nature. All choices are difficult here. In any cost-benefit analysis, it would be unwise to leave out economics. India has a lot of other business to attend to. It cannot stay engaged on the Pakistan front, nor get imprisoned in a commitment to erupt in war at any moment. America may have given us a pass but not for all-out action or for permanent war. That serves none of its interests. Global investors, too, will not be greatly enthused by a landscape shadowed by flying missiles. Not to speak of the nuclear threat. The chance for India to garner and retain global sympathy rests on it being a mature, restrained state that acts as a stabilising force, especially in South Asia.

For that, it's a given that Pakistan has to change. The world must put pressure on Pakistan through institutions like the IMF to predicate bailouts upon a verifiable, conclusive end to terror. China can play a crucial role in reining in Pakistan if it so wishes because of its dependency. As India is involved, China possibly has other intentions. India has to navigate all these factors nimbly and thoughtfully. Conflict without purpose serves no purpose.



(Aroon Purie)